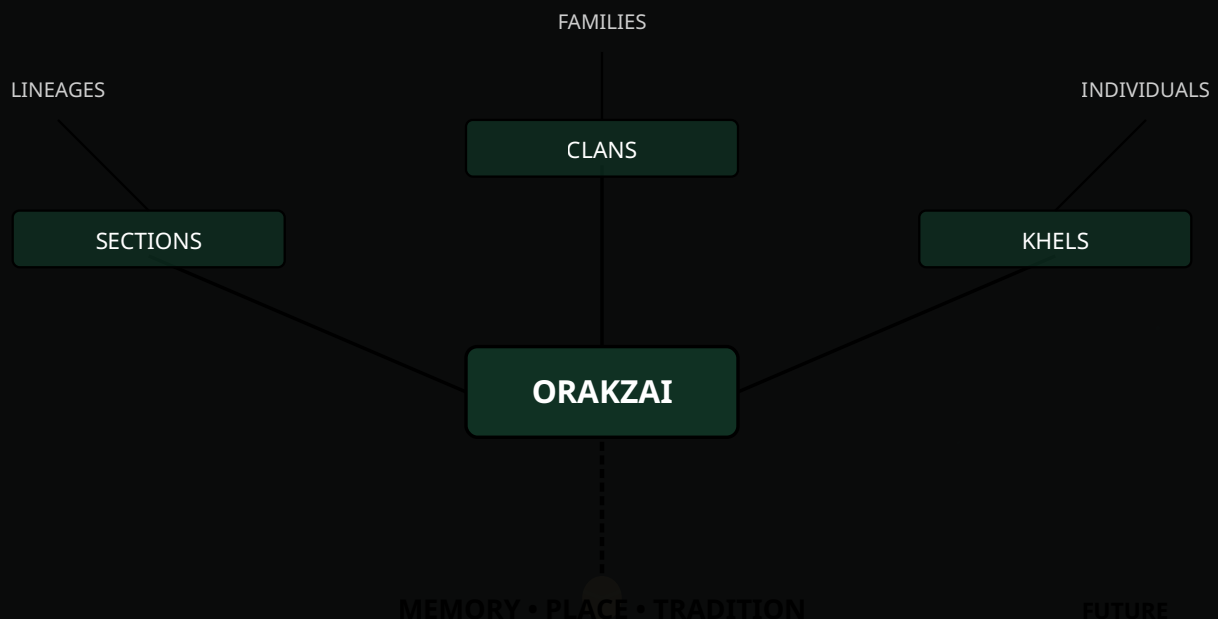


TRIBAL CLANS & LINEAGES

“Where the larger tribe becomes a network of families and memory.”

A tribe is never only a single name. Behind the larger identity are smaller communities: sections, clans, khels, lineages and families. For the Orakzai, historical records describe a complex internal structure in which smaller groups could be identified by ancestral names, local communities and social relationships.

These names were not simply labels. They could connect people to one another, to particular places, and to memories of earlier generations. However, the terminology used by historical sources was not always consistent. A group described as a “clan” in one context might be described as a “section” or “khel” in another. Understanding this vocabulary is therefore essential to navigating the deeper layers of Orakzai identity.¹²



“Conceptual model of tribal and family identity — not a scientifically verified genealogy.”

THE LAYERS OF ORAKZAI IDENTITY

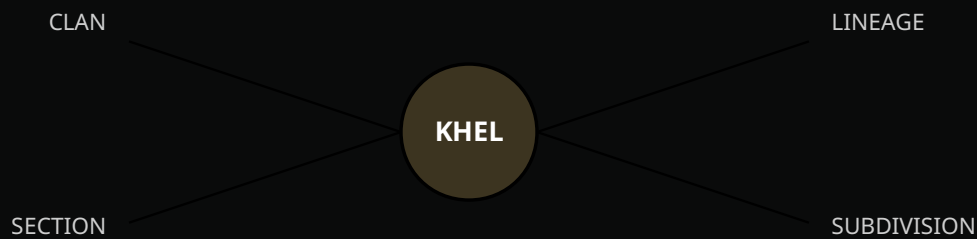
Pashtun tribal organization is often described through a nested hierarchy, moving from the macro scale of the tribe down to the micro scale of the individual. However, historical terminology varies by source. A "khel" might be a clan in one administrative record but a specific lineage in a local family tradition. Understanding these layers requires an analytical approach that respects both documentary evidence and living memory.¹³



“An analytical model — historical terminology varies by source.”

WHAT IS A KHEL?

The term ****Khel**** is central to Pashtun social organization, yet it lacks a rigid, universal definition. Depending on the scale of the group and the context of the source, a Khel may represent a broad clan, a regional section, or a specific family lineage. In Lucas White King’s 1900 monograph, "Khel" is applied to various subdivisions, often reflecting the complexity of Orakzai kinship networks.¹⁴



“Meaning depends on historical and local context.”

THE ORAKZAI CLAN RECORD

One of the most detailed early documentary sources devoted to Orakzai clans is Lucas White King’s *Monograph on the Orakzai Country and Clans* (1900). While valuable for its extensive record of names and settlements, it must be read as a colonial administrative snapshot rather than a neutral description of identity. Contemporary research, such as the entries in *Encyclopaedia Iranica*, provides a necessary cross-check for these historical classifications.

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✓ DOCUMENTED ≈ TRADITIONAL ? UNCERTAIN ○ UNVERIFIED

GROUP	SOURCE TERM	SOURCE	CONFIDENCE
DAWLATZAI	Subtribe / Section	King (1900), Iranica	✓
ISMAILZAI	Main Clan / Section	King (1900), NPS	✓
ALI KHEL	Hamsaya / Section	King (1900), CTC	✓
MAMOZAI	Upper Section	King (1900), NPS	✓
MISHTI	Hamsaya Clan	King (1900), Britannica	✓
BIZOTI	Clan / Khel	King (1900)	✓

“Historical Orakzai groups documented in primary and secondary academic sources.”

ORAL VS. DOCUMENTARY GENEALOGY

A responsible understanding of Orakzai history requires cross-checking oral traditions with documentary evidence. While family stories and elders preserve living memory, official records and academic ethnographies provide a different form of historical anchoring. Where these two forms of evidence overlap, a stronger and more reliable history emerges.¹⁵

ORAL TRADITION

- Family Stories
- Elders' Memory
- Remembered Ancestors
- Local Traditions
- Community Narratives

DOCUMENTARY RECORD

- Official Archives
- Historical Monographs
- Land Records
- Published Ethnographies
- Academic Research

CROSS-CHECK → STRONGER HISTORY

GENEALOGICAL HUMILITY

A responsible family tree should contain empty spaces. An empty space represents the honesty of "we do not know," which is always superior to an invented name. By marking uncertainty and acknowledging the limits of our knowledge, we protect the integrity of Orakzai history for future generations.¹

KNOWN ✓

UNCERTAIN ?

UNKNOWN ○

"UNKNOWN IS BETTER THAN INVENTED."

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

The deeper I look into Orakzai history, the more I realize that a tribe is not a single line. It is a network. Names connect to names, families connect to families, and generations connect through memory. I believe the responsibility of my generation is not to fill every empty space with a story. It is to preserve what we know, investigate what we can, and have the honesty to say when we do not know. That is how lineage becomes history without becoming mythology.

"Behind every tribal name are families, memories, and generations."

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS

